



Chanukah: Light Up Your World

Teacher Guide

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BIG IDEA: The order of lighting the Chanukah candles symbolizes the essential Torah value of accentuating positive character development, before uprooting negative character traits, a Torah ideal worth spreading.

By the end of this class, students will:

Know: The Torah order, and manner, of lighting the Chanukah candles.

Connect: Participants will feel a sense of connection to Jewish tradition by understanding an ancient legal argument as a discussion that is relevant to their lives.

Experience Torat Hayyim: Students will develop their characters in a positive fashion, rather than by focusing on their negative traits.

Feel a sense of mission to: Find opportunities to share Torah ideas with others, thereby spreading Torah light to their circle of family and friends.

A. Set Induction #1: Comparison of Electric Light, Candlelight and Fire

Purpose of Activity: Students will compare attributes of electricity, candlelight and fire, with particular focus on electricity supplying positive light, fire being destructive in nature and candlelight providing a combination.

To the leader: If your setting allows, you may bring in a candle, and perhaps, a picture of a forest fire, and, of course, avail yourself of the electrical lights in the room – to enhance the discussion. If you have access to a white board, you might set up a chart, along these lines:

Across the top, you'd write 3 column headings, entitled: "Electric Light", "Uncontrolled Fire" and "Candlelight".

Allow the women to be creative in answering the following discussion questions, and note them on the board where possible.

Important Note: Many ideas will likely result from this discussion – some comments appear below – to allow for an enhanced conversation. For this module, you'll want to particularly bring out the concept that electrical lighting illuminates (a positive end), fire destroys (a negative end) and candlelight – essentially a "controlled" fire – accomplishes both.



Discussion Questions:

- Ask the women to compare and contrast the 3 – their purpose, positive or negative, the mood that is created, etc. Take note of any other comments.

Comment: Classically, fire, in the Temple was used to burn, to consume sacrifices; thus it was destructive. With other mitzvot, e.g., Shabbat candles, the purpose was to illuminate. (Therefore, if candles are unavailable, e.g., when in a hospital, many Torah authorities allow electrical light to be used for Shabbat candles).

On the other hand, Chanukah candles require both aspects – light and a flame – this is why the candles must be placed where they will be visible (“light”) and electrical candles do not fulfill the basic mitzvah (“flame”).

- Consider “fire”: Ask, “Is fire a physical entity or a spiritual one? Notice that a) it always “goes up” and, b) lighting another fire from it doesn’t deplete the flame. What might these symbolize?

Comment: Fire is considered the least physical entity of the physical world – it symbolizes “reaching higher”, as in spiritual growth. Also, as we will discuss later, spreading the light of Torah, and other essential goodness, e.g., doing *chessed* (loving-kindness), doesn’t deplete us.

B. How do we light Chanukah candles?

Note to Leader: The purpose of this activity is to introduce the women to the manner of lighting candles on each night of Chanuka.

Introductory question: Ask the women how many candles we light each night. They will (likely) respond with the classic answer of 1 on the first night, 2 on the second and so forth. The following source gives a fuller picture of the mitzva of Chanukah candle lighting.

Source: Eliyahu Kitov, *The Book of Our Heritage*, Vol. I, pages 274-5 (1978)

HOW THE LIGHTS ARE TO BE LIT

On the first night one light is lit, and every successive night another light is added till the eighth night when eight lights are lit.

If one has a ‘menorah’ containing eight lights, on the first night he lights the one on the extreme right. The following night he adds the one immediately to the left and kindles it first. He then turns to the right and kindles the light of the previous night. He follows the same procedure each night, always adding from right to left but always lighting from left to right.

...



The lights are to be placed in a straight row; none higher or lower than the others, none receding or protruding out, and none in a circle. There also should be sufficient space between one light and the other, so that the flame of one might not be joined to that of the others; and so that the heat of one light might not melt wax of another.....

It is customary to light one extra light in addition to the required number of lights for the given night. The extra light is called the ‘shamash’ (the servant). The ‘shamash’ [is] used for kindling other lights, and one may derive benefit from its light. The Chanukah lights themselves however, may not be used for any other purpose, while they burn in fulfillment of the mitzva.”

Discussion Questions:

- Suggestion: If you bring a menorah and candles to the class, you may ask one of the women to demonstrate the lighting, on e.g., the sixth night, or you might do it yourself! (Caveat: Don’t actually light the candles if the fire codes don’t permit it in your setting!)
- For the math-inclined, ask how many candles will be lit, in total. (Answer: 44)
- What do the details of *how* to light the candles tell you about the *ideas* behind this mitzvah?

C. Connecting the Physical Mitzvah and its Spiritual Underpinnings: **Miller, A Gift for Yom Tov, page 199-201 (1998)**

Note to Leader: The purpose of reading this selection is to introduce the women to a surprising discussion in the Talmud on the manner of lighting candles on each night of Chanuka and, then, to an underlying philosophical construct, analogizing different methods of personal growth - i.e., focusing on positive and negative character traits.

“The [Talmud records] a difference of opinion between the schools of Hillel and Shammai [two leading Rabbis in the Talmud] concerning the preferred way to kindle the Chanukah lights. Beis [the school of] Hillel say to light one candle the first night of Chanukah, two candles the second night and three the third, and so on to eight candles on the eighth and last night. But Beis [the school of] Shammai say to light eight candles the first night, seven the second night, and continually decrease the number by one until, on the last night of Chanukah, only a single candle is lit.

Of course, today we follow the opinion of Beis Hillel; ... [but what] was Beis Shammai’s ultimate reason, and what was the fundamental point on which [they] disagree?

...

[As noted above] Chanukah candles are a burning flame, symbolizing the destruction of the negative, the burning up of all that is bad. The candles are also a light, symbolizing the triumph of the positive, the light of Torah and all that is good.



These two elements, removing the negative and building up the positive, were two aspects of the original Chanukah story. The Maccabees had to battle against the oppression of the Syrian-Greeks, and also against the influence of Greek paganism and hedonistic materialism, to vanquish it and to burn it up. But Chanukah also meant the rededication of the *Beis HaMikdash* (Holy Temple) and rededication to the positive aspects of Judaism in general. ...

Our mitzva of Chanukah lights today is to commemorate the burning flame, to destroy the bad, and also to recall the light of Torah and the *Beis HaMikdash*, to spread the good. But which aspect is more important? Although we need both, which aspect is more necessary for us to focus on [first], as individuals and as a nation?

To this question, Beis Shammai answers: Before you can develop the positive, you must first uproot that which is negative.... Someone who is not pure of heart, who is not pure of character, is not yet ready to enter the world of spiritual ideals.

Beis Hillel will agree that Beis Shammai has a valid point. But, if you cannot begin the quest for the good until you have purified yourself from all that is bad, you may never come to know what goodness truly is. If a person places his entire focus on his faults, if a person has low self-esteem and thinks himself unworthy of anything holy, his negative self-evaluation may be accurate; but the only way to overcome that is to accentuate the positive, to enter the world of Torah and allow the Torah's light to spread its illuminating effect."

Discussion Questions:

Introductory note: To assist the women in understanding the central concept of focusing on positive character development, before uprooting the negative, give examples, e.g., of the stingy person who makes a commitment to give *tzedaka* (charity), even before doing the "inner work" of changing the negative character trait of lack-of-generosity.

Also, please note that some women may want to discuss the historical context of Chanuka, as described here by Rabbi Miller (as it may be new information, to some), but try to move the conversation in the direction of the "personal growth" point.

First, we'll address this character development on an individual basis:

- Ask the women what they think of the Beis Hillel and Beis Shammai approaches to personal growth and development. You might ask 2 students to debate the pros and cons of the two approaches.
- Have participants work in *chevruta* pairs to share personal stories where one approach worked better than the other. Or, where they might have wished they'd have taken another approach.



- Lastly, invite the women to compile a list of negative character traits (the “whiteboard” will come in handy, again!) and, creatively, think of ways to uproot each with proactive, positive actions.

Now, on a national basis:

- How might these approaches apply in our families, communities and among the Jewish people? Think of changes you’d like to see in the way people conduct themselves *bein adam l’chaveiro* (between man and man, i.e., in interpersonal relationships) and what plans they would recommend for positive change, following Beis Hillel’s approach.

D. Bringing It Home/ Living Our Mission: Spreading the Light of Torah Among Our Families and Our Communities

The purpose of this source is to empower the women to teach others, and identify opportunities to do so, in their everyday life. The source is very powerful and I encourage you, the teacher, to read the article, in its entirety, as it strongly supports your work, in this and other venues. I have abbreviated it for the purpose of this module.

Instead of reading this together, you may wish to ask the participants to read it on their own and underline the three points that resonated most with them. You can then open by having participants read out loud a line that they underlined, and explain why.

Source: “Growth Through Teaching” by Rabbi Noah Weinberg [abbreviated version]
(<http://www.aish.com/sp/48w/48964156.html>)

Don't let your idea remain a hazy notion in your imagination. Transmit it to others and make it a reality.

Most people don't think of themselves as teachers. "Me? A teacher?!" We view teaching as a profession that requires formal training and certification. Besides, we reason, there's probably a "natural ability" that makes someone a good teacher.

To attain wisdom for living, teaching needs to be a basic way of life. Why? Because if you can't teach an idea, then you don't really know it yourself. Having to explain an idea to others forces you to clarify it for yourself. You examine everything much more thoroughly – the details, logical progression, etc. And you'll become personally moved by the idea.

By reaching others, you will reach yourself.

Obligation to Teach

Teaching is also a profound moral obligation. The worst disease is – ignorance. When you reduce ignorance in the world, even by a little bit, you give a great gift to mankind. Some diseases only a doctor can treat, but ignorance can be cured by everyone who takes wisdom seriously. Help cure the international ignorance problem. Teach wisdom.



The Drive to Communicate

Everyone enjoys making a difference in people's lives. Teaching is a way to build an eternal bond with another person. With one piece of wisdom you can help humanity.

Don't Bore Your Audience

What you're teaching has to be relevant. Teaching means to reach someone, to get him to appreciate what you feel is important. You may want to start with a joke or story to get his attention and draw him in.

Encourage your students to ask questions that unlock the essence of the message. When someone asks a question, it's a sign he's in the learning mode. Never lose sight of your audience. You have to "feel" how they're reacting to your message. People are generally willing to listen to anything – if it's said in a way they can appreciate and understand.

Clarify Your Goal

Be clear and concise. Pinpoint in stark, simple terms what you want to communicate. If you can't summarize your message in one or two sentences, it's not clear enough in your mind. Start teaching, start reaching.

Teach, Don't Preach

Preaching is giving over information with fire and brimstone, without paying attention to what your audience is feeling. That's not teaching. That's brainwashing. And that is totally *not* the Jewish way.

What is teaching? Teaching is communicating to an independent human the clarity of a concept. To teach is to get others to see and understand it on their own terms. To enable the student to get in touch with what he already knows – and re-discover it on his own.

An impassioned teacher can be inspiring and uplifting, but ultimately, a teacher has to be able to convey ideas in a way that emotions don't interfere and distort the message.

Make It Real

Know your material inside and out. Before communicating an idea, review the main points. This builds confidence, so at the moment of teaching, you can focus less on content and more on presentation.

It has to invigorate you. This will translate into your personal sincerity coming through. For as the Sages say: "What comes from the heart, goes into the heart."

Inspire Action

Teaching is not just conveying bits and bytes of information; it's about effecting a change in behavior. Figure out how to transmit an idea, so that others will not only appreciate it, but will actually put it into practice. Otherwise, you haven't succeeded in "teaching."

Ideas impact people. Ideas change the way people think – and give them the tools to change the way they act.

Develop a good lesson plan. Work through the stages of bringing people to actual implementation.



Discussion Questions to Ask the Women:

- Do you agree with Rabbi Weinberg's view that everyone can be a teacher? That everyone has a moral obligation to teach?
- What do you think of his equating "preaching" & "brainwashing" and that they are not the Jewish way? Is this a surprise to you?
- Are you a "teacher", according to his description? Would you like to become one?
- Return to the discussion of "fire" in section A. Consider the reality that lighting a candle does not deplete the fire of the first candle. How does this apply to teaching Torah? What resonates for you from this analogy?
- Think of the Torah lesson you learned today – to first work on positive growth, and then on uprooting the "bad", and how it is learned from the remarkable disagreement between Beis Shammai and Beis Hillel. Identify one person whom you'd like to share this concept with (friend, relative, neighbor). What "lesson plan" might you have for him/her, e.g., a joke or story to open the conversation? How would you share this idea in a manner that appeals to them? Think about how your teaching would differ if it is a child, teenager, adult, etc. Consider how your approach might differ if you are a close friend of your prospective "student", rather than a mere acquaintance. (If the women share their creative ideas for teaching this concept, they will all benefit and more teaching will occur, thanks to you and them!) In what ways could you teach these and other lessons in a casual, non-judgmental manner?
- Think of today's lesson in the context of the Chanukah holiday. How might you share this wisdom with someone who is less knowledgeable than you?
- Finally, encourage the women to take the approach of being a teacher of other Torah ideas and ask them to think of other pieces of Torah wisdom that they would want to teach.

LIGHT UP YOUR WORLD!